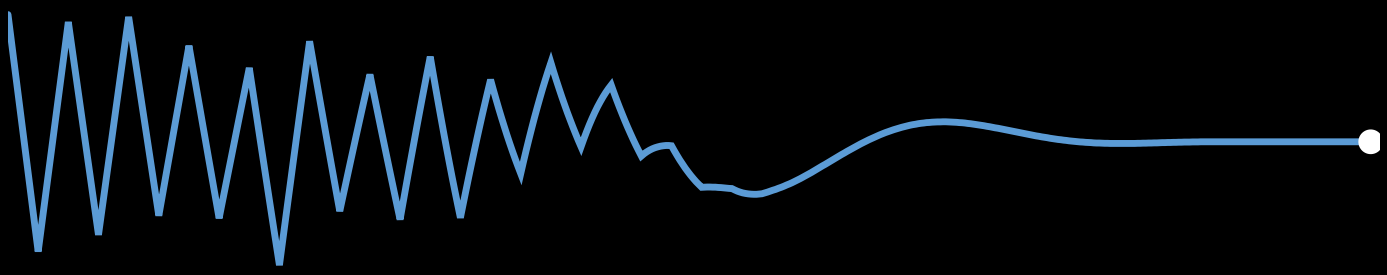
From Meltdown *To* Resolution



20 Veteran Mediator Scripts for Resolving Emotion-Driven Workplace Conflicts

Repair Relationships • Gain Control • Lead with Compassion

L. THERESE WHITE

Employment Mediator • Workplace Conflict Coach

From Meltdown To Resolution

20 Veteran Mediator Scripts for Resolving

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Welcome

> *"The difference between conflicts that escalate into emotional firestorms and those that turn into collaborative resolutions often comes down to a handful of carefully chosen and well-timed sentences."*

I'm really glad you're here.

Since 1992, I've been repairing severely broken workplace relationships by helping people work together in genuine collaborative peace . . . not just "stopping the fighting."

Most workplace conflicts aren't really about the easily seen surface issues. They're about unaddressed and often hidden personal dynamics that no one knows how to talk about.

Across well over a thousand mediations and coaching assignments, I've learned that helping people understand their own emotions is what finally surfaces the thing actually driving the trouble.

These scripts I'm sharing in this short booklet will help you navigate those moments when everything's about to explode, and you don't know what to say or do.

Please know I'm here for you if you ever need further assistance.

Then we will pick up the pieces together.

Sincerely,



L. Therese White

ThereseWhite.com

The stories in this guide are composites drawn from more than a thousand mediations across three decades. Names, industries, and identifying details have been changed or combined. No account describes a single identifiable matter or party.

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Introduction

The Conversation Nobody Is Having

Everyone answers to somebody.

The team leader answers to his team and to a director. The director answers to a vice president. And the vice president answers to the CEO, the board, or the managing partner who wants to know why this thing still isn't handled.

So when a workplace conflict catches fire, it is never just two people in an office. It is everyone up and down the line, waiting.

Here is what thirty-plus years of mediating these conflicts has taught me:

Most of us are not afraid of the logical part of a workplace dispute.

Facts, policies, procedures, investigations, plain old common sense . . . we can handle those. We were trained for those.

What keeps us up at night, grinding our teeth, is the other part. The runaway emotions. Things like . . .

Performance review meltdowns. Political shouting matches.

Trance-like shutdown. No-holds-barred turf wars.

"Fire me! I'll see you in court." "This is B.S.! You can't do this to me!"

Polarizing culture clashes.

And it does not matter whether you are five years into this work or thirty. I have been doing it since 1992, and runaway emotions can still catch me sideways.

Recognizing and handling emotion is not a soft skill. It is the ground everything else stands on. Skip it, and you are building on sand.

Introduction

Here's Some Good News

After working with hundreds of organizations . . . ranging from Fortune 500 companies to government agencies, faith-based institutions, and mission-driven nonprofits . . . I've identified a pattern:

> ***Whether you're looking at a situation that quietly resolves itself or one that becomes the next harassment case study, it often hinges on one loaded conversation. One pressure-cooked moment where just the right approach protects reputations, rebuilds bridges, and solves the "real" problem. Get it wrong? That's when "routine personnel matters" become front-page news.***

I have used these scripts, or versions of them, since before some of you started your careers.

They are not magic. They are what I reach for when a room is about to come apart.

Think of them as emotional "circuit breakers." That is, they interrupt escalation cycles . . . creating space for cooler heads to prevail.

Now, before we move too far along, please know that none of these scripts are new or revolutionary. You've used, seen, read, or heard about them throughout your career, if not your entire life.

So, What Makes Them Different?

It's simple. They're specifically designed to minimize dangerous, embarrassing, and possibly career-threatening mistakes.

And I've organized them into categories that will help you know exactly when, why, and how to use them.

Book your free Confidential Conflict Assessment. Details at the end of this guide.

How to Use This Guide

Let This Be Your Emergency-Planning Toolkit

This is for those moments when workplace emotions threaten to derail productive conversations.

Dog-ear the pages. Highlight what pops out. And practice the scripts until they become second nature.

They aren't to be recited like a robot. They're tools you'll adapt to your exact situation and personal style.

And the result? You'll spend less time putting out emotional fires and more time building a workplace where conflicts become opportunities for professional and personal growth.

A Gift For You: To make this guide even more useful, there's a One-Page Cheat Sheet on page 22. Print it, keep it handy, and share it.

> *"After more than thirty years of working with Therese White, both as a co-mediator and co-trainer, I can honestly say she is an extraordinary talent. We have tackled some very difficult and challenging cases together; many filled with raw emotion or revolving around deep-seated life experience issues.*
>
> *Therese is especially skilled in the transformational mediation model. She doesn't just want to stop the fighting, but to "help" the parties fix their broken working relationships. Beyond mediation, she has been an invaluable co-teacher and assistant in several of my conflict resolution classes at Pepperdine University Law School and in my mediator certification trainings at the Center for Conflict Resolution.*
>
> *Therese is highly empathetic and an outstanding creative problem solver, with deep knowledge and unstinting dedication to our work. For genuine, deep, lasting resolutions in any employment setting, Therese should be your first choice."*
>
> **Kenneth Cloke — Mediator, Author, Educator, and Co-Founder of Mediators Beyond Borders**

When These Scripts Are Not the Right Tool

These scripts are for everyday workplace friction: the clash of styles, the tense meeting, the relationship that has gone sideways.

They are not for a complaint of harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or a safety concern. If someone has raised one, or you suspect one is in play, stop. Do not try to talk it through with these scripts. Your organization may have a legal duty to act, and a well-meant "let's work this out between us" can cost someone their right to be heard, and cost you more than you'd want to know.

Bring in HR, legal counsel, or your investigation process first. Mediation may come later, if and when the right people decide it is appropriate.

This guide offers communication tools, not legal advice.

My Foundational Scripts

Listening Deeply

My many years of mediating hundreds of workplace conflicts in crisis have taught me that listening deeply and making people feel heard are among the first steps to calming emotions. Often, when I let the discussion move away from even the most minor issue too soon, emotions escalate and sometimes explode. Why? It's because someone felt cut off and disrespected. And then, you know what hits the fan.

Key Scripts I Use:

1. **"I hear you."**

   > I use this when someone is expressing frustration, anger, or hurt. These three simple words acknowledge the person's reality without judgment.

2. **"So, from your perspective . . . [paraphrase their viewpoint]."**

   > Use this after someone shares their experience. This shows there's a genuine effort to understand.

3. **"Tell me, what's most important to you?"**

   > When people are stuck, this shifts the conversation from positions to interests, and hidden needs often surface as a bonus.

How I Used Them:

I was interviewing a staff member in preparation for a mediation with his boss. He felt repeatedly overlooked for promotions. After he let loose his frustration, I simply said, "I hear you."

I watched his whole body relax. Nothing was solved in that moment. But the conversation stopped being about the complaint he was drafting in his head . . . and started being about what he deeply wanted from his career.

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Prioritizing Empathy

Empathy is one of the most powerful ways to strengthen connection, even in the most heated situations. **And** it encourages the receiver to give empathy back. Unlike agreement, empathy acknowledges feelings and experiences without necessarily sharing the same viewpoint. That simple distinction has saved so many of my mediations and coaching assignments over the years.

Key Scripts I Use:

4. **"I can see why this matters so much to you."**

   > This validates the importance of the issue without judging their emotional reaction.

5. **"Wow! That sounds [frustrating, disappointing, painful, etc.]."**

   > I've found that accurately naming the specific emotion grabs their attention and makes you more trustworthy.

How I Used Them:

I remember watching a team leader use the "I can see why this matters . . ." phrase when her entire staff was furious about a last-minute project change. Instead of telling them they were overreacting or "that's just how it is," she said she was furious, too. Then, everyone quickly moved into problem-solving. That little bit of empathy was what let the room move.

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Building Rapport and Trust

People in conflict expect negative feedback. Knowing this, I build rapport by openly complimenting something someone has said or done. Being honest about my feelings . . . especially the positive ones . . . helps build or restore the trust and respect needed for difficult conversations.

Key Scripts I Use:

6. **"I really appreciate your willingness to discuss this."**

   > I begin nearly every mediation or pre-mediation interview with some version of this. It acknowledges that showing up for difficult conversations takes courage. And that's always taken as a compliment.

7. **"I've noticed positive changes in [specific behavior]. Thank you."**

   > For example, if I point out an improvement in someone's demeanor, this positive reinforcement makes this and maybe other improvements more likely to continue.

How I Used Them:

During a complex mediation with multiple grievances festering for years, I said, "I really like what you two are doing together here." The parties were shocked to realize that they could work together. After that, the conversation changed from "We can't work together" to "We have a few specific things to work out."

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Appealing to Their Higher Selves

Understanding someone's aspirations or desired self-image can be incredibly persuasive in encouraging positive behavior. Instead of appealing to logic, I often appeal to their capacity to contribute or their need to be respected. Understanding and appealing to their internal motivations has proven very effective in my practice . . . and at home.

Key Scripts I Use:

8. **"I've heard you've always done the right thing. Tell me, what do you think the right thing looks like today?"**

   > This invites reflection on their self-image and legacy, which often outweighs the immediate issue.

9. **"You seem to be resourceful when tackling challenges. Do you have a creative solution for this situation?"**

   > My goal here is to connect their behavior with a positive identity they will probably want to live up to. And it encourages ownership of the solution because it's theirs.

How I Used Them:

During a post-mediation coaching session with a defense contractor vice president, I thought he was still dismissive of one of his people. So I appealed to his higher self and asked, directly, whether this was costing him his reputation as a fair leader.

He got quiet. Then he asked me what I had noticed. That question was the opening.

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Regulating Your Own Emotions

Through decades of high-stakes mediations, I've learned that how I say something often matters more than what I say. That's why I use a calm, slow voice . . . especially when I want to disagree or introduce difficult topics. And when I start feeling angry or upset, I use that as my cue to pause and get centered. Remember, you're the most important person to be centered in any emotion-driven conflict. You can't help others regulate themselves if you're unregulated.

Key Scripts I Use:

10. **"I'm feeling [specific emotion]. I want to take a brief moment if you don't mind."**

    > Naming my strong emotions reduces their power over me, and it helps others see I'm trying very hard.

11. **"Give me a moment. I want to respond thoughtfully."**

    > This buys me time to rein in my emotions when I'm tempted to speak from anger or frustration.

12. **"Hey, let's take a break and catch our breath."**

    > Pauses interrupt the escalation cycle.

How I Used Them:

Both parties in a harassment mediation at a nonprofit made comments that triggered me. Rather than reacting, I calmly said, "I notice I'm feeling concerned about the direction we're headed. Let's take a break and come back in 10 minutes." That brief pause allowed me to gather my wits and make a plan. I decided to talk with the parties individually about their behavior and its impact on me before bringing them back to the table.

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Separating the Person from the Problem

It's simple. If I want someone to listen instead of getting defensive, I focus on what they did, not who I think they are. I'm calling out the action, not the person. That way, they're less likely to feel like I'm tearing them down as a human. After all, I'm just pointing out something that isn't working.

Key Scripts I Use:

13 **"Let's talk about [specific behavior]. What help would you like?"**

> Addressing behavioral change as a collaborative effort signals that growth is a process, not a personal failing.

14 **"I saw/heard about that [specific behavior]. What do you think contributes to that?"**

> Neutral observations mixed with open-ended questions encourage self-reflection. They help identify patterns without feeling judged or becoming defensive.

How I Used Them:

I facilitated a team discussion about a project that was failing. Team members were silently pointing fingers at one person. Seeing this, and its effect on that person, I asked the team, "Is there anything about your process that contributed to this?" Within a few minutes, the team was talking about task handoffs and unclear priorities instead of about a person.

> *". . . The most exceptional thing about Therese is her quiet way of lighting the path to common ground. Her understanding of how emotional intelligence impacts individuals and teams sets her apart from other mediators, especially when developing grassroots community leaders . . . Over the years, we've trained countless professionals in our conflict resolution methods, and I can confidently say she's one of the best in the field."*
>
> **Joan Goldsmith — Leadership Development Consultant, Mediator, Educator, and Author**

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Finding Common Ground

I always try my best to find shared interests and priorities, especially in the most contentious situations. Most people expect disagreement in conflict. So when I uncover agreement on almost anything, it immediately defuses anger. Even when I struggle to agree with their position, I can usually find something about their intentions, concerns, or values that I can authentically support.

Key Scripts I Use:

15 **"Let's clarify what we agree on and what we still see differently."**

> This signals that disagreement isn't a threat, encouraging the future openness and vulnerability that only happens with trust.

16 **"It sounds like you both care about [shared value]. How can you build on that here?"**

> Identifying common ground first makes compromise feel like alignment of priorities or values rather than concession.

17 **"What would make this solution seem fair to everyone involved?"**

> I'll use this when a potential compromise looks very one-sided. It shifts the focus from "winning" to fairness, because it invites everyone to have an equal stake in the outcome.

How I Used Them:

I almost blew this one. Three junior pastors at a large church were finger-pointing over low ticket sales for a concert two weeks away. I nearly jumped into full mediation mode. But I paused instead and said: "You still want this concert to be a big success? And there's still time, right?" Their shoulders dropped. One sighed: "Yes, we just disagree on how to get there."

That tiny agreement became their anchor. They spent the next hour arguing about the plan instead of about each other.

Your Notes

My Foundational Scripts

Being Vulnerable

Vulnerability tears down walls fast. Getting even one person in the conflict to be vulnerable and totally honest is rare. So when I become vulnerable, it changes the entire dynamic and opens doors faster than anything else I know.

Key Scripts I Use:

18 **"I dropped the ball earlier by not seeing your [painful emotion] sooner. Can you talk about it now?"**

> Owning mistakes builds trust. It shows vulnerability and encourages others to do the same.

19 **"I really want us to win here, but please tell me if there's anything important I should change."**

> This frames vulnerability as a path to shared success. And it can uncover hidden information that changes everything for the better.

20 **"This part scares me a little. Are you feeling that too?"**

> I found that sharing the same fears creates emotional safety and, therefore, more openness.

How I Used Them:

Toward the end of a mediation between a university's head librarian and a staff member working from home, I asked: "What support would help you both uphold the expectations you've agreed on?" The staff member hesitated, then shared a caregiving obligation at home that no one at work had known about. The librarian adjusted deadlines that afternoon and pointed him toward campus resources.

Your Notes

Bonus Scripts

"Self-Talk" for Managing Your Conflict Resolution Stress

When You're Feeling Overwhelmed by Your Own Emotions

- "I know I'm feeling [overwhelmed / anxious / frustrated] right now."
- "This is natural."
- "These emotions are information, not directives. They won't control me."
- "So I choose to connect with my best self."

Before Entering a Difficult Conversation

- "I'm fully prepared for this conversation, no matter what."
- "Feeling nervous is normal. It shows I care. I don't need to be perfect."
- "My only role is to facilitate understanding and provide support."
- "I'll focus on listening before responding."
- "I trust myself and my process."

When Facing Strong Resistance or Hostility

- "Their reaction probably isn't personal. If it is, so what?"
- "It probably signals fear or unmet needs rather than an attack on my competence."
- "I don't need to be liked right now. I'll remain calm and focused on the task."
- "I have been in hard rooms before. And I know when and how to step away."

Reflection After a Disappointing Conflict Intervention

- "I did my best with the information and resources I had."
- "Regardless of the immediate outcome, I created space for dialogue that wasn't there before."
- "It's normal to replay conversations and think of better responses. Reflection helps me grow."
- "I'll identify the things I did well and poorly."
- "I've grown from this."

Your Notes

Bonus Scripts

Making the Case for Outside Help

Whether you are briefing your director, your CEO, or your board

Every one of us answers to somebody. If you lead a team, this is the conversation with your director. If you run HR, it is the conversation with your CEO, your board, or your managing partner. If you are the managing partner, it is the conversation with your partners.

The room changes. The structure does not.

Opening Context

- "I've been working with [person/team] regarding [brief issue], but we're at an impasse."
- "This situation involves [communication breakdowns/policy gaps/high emotions]."
- "Despite [discussions, previous intervention], the problem is still affecting [productivity, morale, collaboration]."

Neutral Rationale for External Help

- "I think an outside, third-party mediator could help us work through this."
- "A mediator who specializes in workplace conflict could bring the trust and the tools we need at this point."

Specific Request

- "I've had an initial conversation with [mediator name] about how something like this might work. Nothing is committed."
- "Their role would be to listen to all sides, help identify what's underneath it, and assist the people in building their own solution."

Reassurance and Next Steps

- "This isn't about de-escalation. It's about giving everyone the best chance at resolving this situation for good."
- "The process should take [timeframe]."
- "I'll handle the logistics if you support the approach."
- "How do you feel about this plan? You're welcome to meet with the mediator yourself."

If You Meet Resistance

- On cost or time: “The short-term investment could prevent long-term [turnover, project delays, legal exposure].”
- On skepticism: “I understand the hesitation. We have tried what we have internally. I would rather bring in help while there is still something to work with.”

Your Notes

Bonus Scripts

Introducing Outside Assistance to the People in Conflict

This matters because it frames mediation as constructive rather than punitive, while keeping everyone psychologically safe.

Reducing Defensiveness

- "Many organizations use mediators for exactly this type of situation. It shows a commitment to fairness."
- "When tensions run high, all of us can benefit from a fresh, outside perspective."
- "This isn't about who's right. It's about finding a path forward that works for everyone."
- "Many people feel hesitant at first, but mediation often uncovers common ground no one has seen yet."

Emphasizing Voluntary Buy-In

- "You're in the driver's seat. We'll start only if and when you're comfortable."
- "If at any point you feel uncomfortable, we can pause and reassess."
- "This only works if we all engage openly. Would you like to hear more?"

Explaining the Process

- "[Name of mediator] will meet with everyone separately first, then bring you and [other person] together."
- "The mediator's role is to listen, ask questions, and help uncover solutions that might not be visible yet."
- "Nothing will be decided for you. The mediator is here to guide the conversation, not to judge who's right or wrong."
- "We're not here to rehash every past detail. We're here mostly to work on what happens next."
- "Do you have any questions?"

Giving Reassurance

- "Before anything begins, the mediator will walk everyone through exactly what stays confidential and what does not. You will know the ground rules before you say a word."
- "If emotions run high, we can take a break, or even stop. That is normal and okay."
- "Even small progress is still progress. We'll mark the steps, not just the end point."

Handling Pushback

If they say, "We can handle this ourselves."

- "I believe that too. But after [X attempts], it's clear we need new tools. Let's try this before things get harder."

If they fear punishment: "Is this disciplinary?"

- "Mediation itself isn't discipline. Here is exactly what stays confidential and what doesn't."

If they blame the other party: "They need this, not me."

- "Since the conflict involves both of you, would you be willing to test whether this could save you both time and frustration?"

Your Notes

Do You Need an Outside Mediator?

How to Decide

The scripts in this guide, combined with your own experience, will carry many workplace conflicts a long way. There are situations where they will not, and bringing in an outside mediator is the better call:

- When the people involved no longer trust the internal process, or the people who run it.
- When you want to make one more real attempt before moving to something more formal.
- When there is a genuine power or status gap between the parties.
- When a complaint has been raised and reviewed, nothing in the finding requires anyone to leave, and the working relationship is still broken.
- When the conflict is old, layered, and has survived every previous fix.
- When the emotions are too raw for anyone inside the organization to hold.

An outside mediator is not seen as taking sides. We know which questions to ask, and when. And sometimes a fresh set of eyes is simply what a room needs.

> **If a complaint of harassment, discrimination, or retaliation is involved, start with HR or counsel, not with mediation or these scripts.**

Your Notes

What to Expect From Me

I Help Uncover and Resolve the Emotional Drivers of the Conflict

This means I don't aim for fast transactional settlements, because they don't hold. Instead, I facilitate conversations that move people from winner-take-all battles to mutual problem-solving and agreements they can actually live with.

My approach is most effective when:

- The organization is fully committed to keeping both people.
- Repairing the working relationship matters as much as stopping the fighting.
- The conflict involves complex, deep-rooted emotional dynamics . . . not legal or transactional matters.
- Follow-up support, like coaching, may be needed to make it hold.

You and I can measure success by asking:

- Was a written agreement or a basic understanding reached within an agreed-upon timeframe?
- Was a professional working relationship (re)established, even if it never becomes a friendly one?
- Did learning to self-navigate future disagreements reduce repeat occurrences?
- Are **you** free to focus on strategic priorities instead of firefighting?

> *"Therese has provided mediation services for my clients over the past seven or eight years. My clients' reason for using mediation is to address unresolved and rising conflict among individuals who work together, in person and remotely. I chose Therese to support these clients because of her skill in helping people repair damage to their relationships. Her approach to mediation is transformative — both the style and the outcome. Therese believes in educating people, which is an added gift. She carries that into her sessions, allowing her to change not only the situation at hand but also to create new ways of looking at future situations, thereby bringing about lasting change."*
>
> **Candace Gottlieb-Clark — Founder/CEO, Dynamic Team Solutions**

THE CHEAT SHEET · FROM MELTDOWN TO RESOLUTION

20 Veteran Mediator Scripts

for Resolving Emotion-Driven Workplace Conflicts

Listening Deeply

1. "I hear you."
2. "So, from your perspective . . . [paraphrase their viewpoint]."
3. "Tell me, what's most important to you?"

Prioritizing Empathy

4. "I can see why this matters so much to you."
5. "Wow! That sounds [frustrating, disappointing, painful, etc.]."

Building Rapport and Trust

6. "I really appreciate your willingness to discuss this."
7. "I've noticed positive changes in [specific behavior]. Thank you."

Appealing to Their Higher Selves

8. "I've heard you've always done the right thing. Tell me, what do you think the right thing looks like today?"
9. "You seem to be resourceful when tackling challenges. Do you have a creative solution for this situation?"

Remember, you're the most important person to be centered in any emotion-driven conflict. You can't help others regulate themselves if you're unregulated.

Regulating Your Own Emotions

10. "I'm feeling [specific emotion]. I want to take a brief moment if you don't mind."
11. "Give me a moment. I want to respond thoughtfully."
12. "Hey, let's take a break and catch our breath."

Separating the Person from the Problem

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Being Vulnerable

18. "I dropped the ball earlier by not seeing your [painful emotion] sooner. Can you talk about it now?"
19. "I really want us to win here, but please tell me if there's anything important I should change."
20. "This part scares me a little. Are you feeling that too?"

How to use this sheet: Print it. Pin it where you'll see it. Before a hard conversation, pick one or two scripts and say them in your own words. They're tools, not lines to recite. Share it with a colleague.



L. Therese White

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323-291-4813 | Therese@ThereseWhite.com

Free, confidential 30-minute call: calendly.com/therese-theresewhite/30min

Scan to book a call

For everyday workplace friction. These scripts are not for complaints of harassment, discrimination, retaliation, or safety concerns; start with HR or counsel. Not legal advice. Outcomes are not guaranteed.

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Thank You

Your Free Confidential Conflict Assessment Call

If you're sitting with a conflict you cannot get traction on, book a free, confidential 30-minute call. We'll talk about your specific situation. I'll tell you what I see. And then we'll decide together whether I am the right person for it.

Book Your Call Here

If the matter is urgent, call 323-291-4813 or email Therese@ThereseWhite.com with "Urgent" in the subject line. I answer my calls and emails personally.

What you share on this call stays between us, except where the law requires otherwise or someone's safety is at risk. I'm a mediator and coach, not an attorney, so this call isn't legal advice and doesn't create an attorney-client relationship.



L. Therese White

Founder & CEO, Kennedy White, Inc.

Employment Mediator • Workplace Conflict Coach

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